Paul Kabuswe

(kah-BOO-sway)

Minister of Mines and
Minerals Development
Republic of Zambia

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **Sept 2021**

Minister Paul Kabuswe is a confident and larger-than-life politician who has earned admirers and detractors in response to his efforts to revitalize Zambia's mining sector.

- **A Tough Negotiator**
  Kabuswe concluded major deals for both KCM and Mopani Copper Mines. He has warned that “we are going to be very strong in negotiations, but not too strong to the extent of scaring away potential investors.”

- **A Difficult Partner**
  Kabuswe has developed a reputation for being difficult. His reforms have been described as beholden to vested political interests and hobbled by poor communication, engendering intense criticism from the industry.

Kabuswe is quick to congratulate himself for his contributions to the mining sector, brushing aside concerns about the legality, due process, or expected benefits of recently concluded deals.

WHY THEY MATTER

Kabuswe wants Zambia to become a top-five global copper producer and Africa's leading jurisdiction for mining investment and critical minerals development, with a target of 3 million tonnes annually by 2031.

- **Big Promises**
  The Minister has staked his reputation on big dividends, pledging surging investment, production growth, and visible development gains. Zambia has recorded two consecutive years of copper production growth in 2024 and 2025 after a multiyear slump through 2023.

- **Contentious Moves**
  Kabuswe has shown a willingness to make controversial sales decisions. He has declared that the government will "no longer negotiate from a position of weakness," though his attempt to introduce 15 percent free-carry government stakes in critical minerals was rejected by President Hichilema.

Kabuswe sees his mining mandate as a stepping stone to higher office. His past political decisions, including decamping to the ruling party in 2021, speak to his ambition to gain national prominence.

MEETING WITH THEM

Kabuswe is an engaging interlocutor, who tries to keep the conversation moving, even during challenging or contentious discussions.

- **A Straight-Forward Rapporteur**
  Kabuswe tries to balance criticism with pragmatism, expressing his concerns before seeking a solution. When reflecting on a past disagreement, he remarked “I saw the misbehavior…but we also needed to look at what is a bigger picture."

- **An Effective Storyteller**
  Kabuswe loves to share colorful anecdotes to illustrate his point, such as comparing an unfavorable relationship with a foreign corporation to having a"python around the neck". His easy sense of humor, often self-deprecating, puts counterparts at ease.

Kabuswe is unbothered by his limitations, such his lack of a legal background, and undeterred by topics beyond his technical understanding. This approach enables him to sidestep difficult questions, saying “I don't want to be very specific because I might quote wrong figures.”

ON THEIR MIND

- **U.S. Global Health MOU**
  A leaked draft of a $1bn memorandum of understanding between the United States and Zambia on health financing has ignited a firestorm due to its mandatory targets, sharing of data, and reported access to mining concessions.

- **Closed Cooper-Export Corridor Closed**
  Heavy rains in northern Zambia washed away a bridge on the highway south of its main border crossing with Democratic Republic of Congo in early March, severing what’s become one of the world’s most important supply routes for copper.

- **Inflation Slows**
  In February, inflation fell further to 7.5 percent (lowest since March 2019), prompting the central bank to cut its policy rate by 75 basis points. The government released K23.2 billion in January alone to cover wages, debt service, arrears, and operation.

- **Law Expands Parliament’s Size**
  President Hichilema in December 2025 signed into law constitutional changes that will expand the country's parliament to around 280 from 167 seats, a move that critics say could favor his party before a national election in August 2026.

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NETWORK

Kabuswe is a regular presence at global forums and events, courting a diverse range of countries and multinational companies to encourage investment in the mining sector. He has worked with firms like First Quantum, Barrick, Vedanta Resources, KoBold Metals, Ivanhoe Mines, and China Nonferrous Metals Corp.

The Minister's relationship with China has deepened following the elevation of China-Zambia ties to a Comprehensive Strategic and Cooperative Partnership. At the Invest in Zambia International Conference 2025, Kabuswe emphasized the visible benefits of this partnership on the ground. Chinese investments remain significant across Zambia's copper belt.

Kabuswe has hitched his political future to President Hichilema, presenting himself as a reliable ally within the ruling United Party for National Development (UPND).

He is already actively promoting Hichilema's 2026 reelection campaign and has tried to forge partnerships with other ministers—including Commerce, Energy, and Finance—to participate in joint initiatives.

CONTROVERSIES

Kabuswe's tenure has been marked by corruption accusations and public blowback as he positions himself as the mining sector's gatekeeper.

- **Shady Transactions**
  Kabuswe has contended with repeated accusations of corruption from opposition leaders who say the Minister shakes down mining companies. Despite Kabuswe's claims that he is "sparkling clean," allegations of graft continue to shadow his activities.

- **Divisive Deals**
  Kabuswe has faced scrutiny over the government's sale of a 90 percent stake in Mopani Copper Mines to UAE-based Emirate Investment Group. His decision to bring back Vedanta Resources to run Konkola Copper Mine also prompted an outcry given the company's contentious history.

Kabuswe's spat with the opposition Patriotic Front (PF), which he left to join the ruling party, has generated continual drama. The PF has accused Kabuswe of disloyalty and building an extravagant home; Kabuswe's brother claims the house is his, not the Minister's.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Mines and Minerals Development**, Republic of Zambia (2021 to present)
- **Mayor**, Chililabombwe, Zambia (2016 to 2021)
- **Member of Parliament**, Chililabombwe Constituency (2021 to present)

BIO

Growing up in Zambia's mining heartland, Kabuswe's life has revolved around politics and the extractives industry from an early age. Born October 8, 1973, the Minister often refers to his roots in the country's mining region, as well as his charitable work in the community, including a book distribution program.

- **Steeped in Political Science**
  Kabuswe went to primary and secondary school in his home town of Chililabombwe, and later earned a bachelors of science in political science at the University of the Copperbelt in Kitwe, only 40 miles away from home.

- **Anchored in Faith**
  Kabuswe appears to be deeply committed to Christianity, with faith playing a significant role in his public and political life. He attends local church events, such as the Worship Powerhouse Church in Lusaka, and participates in gospel music events.

Kabuswe is married. He speaks English and presumably Bemba, the main language of the Zambian Copperbelt. On his National Assembly profile page, it says his hobby is "sport."

NOTES